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Learning in Committee? How Racial Diversity Shapes Speech, Evidence Use, and Substantive Representation in Congress

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Correspondence: Jacob M. Lollis (lolisjm@ucmail.uc.edu)**Received:** 30 January 2026 | **Revised:** 19 June 2026 | **Accepted:** 1 July 2026**Keywords:** committees | descriptive and substantive representation | evidence-based policymaking | legislatures | race

ABSTRACT

Research on descriptive representation has primarily examined whether and how descriptive representatives themselves advance group interests. In the context of race, this work shows that nonwhite lawmakers advance nonwhite interests, but less is known about whether nonwhite representation also shapes white lawmakers' behavior. I argue that repeated contact with nonwhite lawmakers in racially diverse committees may shape how white Democrats engage race-related issues, making them more likely to support race-related hearing statements with evidence. To test this expectation, I combine large-scale text classification with a detailed content analysis of more than 11,000 race-related committee hearing statements and 87,000 full bill texts from the 105th–117th Congresses. Using a within-legislator design, I find that white Democrats serving on racially diverse committees are more likely to cite evidence when discussing race and to cite the same sources as their nonwhite colleagues. I also show that race-based expertise is associated with substantive representation: legislators who more frequently cite evidence when discussing race are more effective at advancing race-related legislation. Together, these findings suggest that descriptive representation may foster substantive representation, in part, by shaping how white Democrats engage race-related issues in racially diverse legislative committees.

Research on descriptive representation has primarily examined whether and how descriptive representatives themselves advance group interests. Yet the consequences of descriptive representation may extend beyond these lawmakers' own actions. In legislatures, lawmakers repeatedly interact with colleagues in institutional settings where information and expertise are exchanged. In the context of racial representation, these interactions may allow nonwhite lawmakers to introduce race-related information, evidence, and expertise that shape not only their own representational behavior but also how white lawmakers understand and engage race-related issues.

Existing scholarship has focused primarily on the first part of this relationship: how nonwhite lawmakers themselves advance nonwhite interests. Nonwhite lawmakers are more likely than

their white colleagues to sponsor racially salient legislation (Bratton and Haynie 1999; Pinney and Serra 2002; Sinclair-Chapman 2002; Wilson 2010, 2017), foreground race-related issues in committee hearings and floor debate (Minta and Sinclair-Chapman 2013; Wilson 2017; Dietrich and Hayes 2023; Lollis 2025), and create and join caucuses to coordinate race-based representational efforts (Tyson 2016; Clark 2019). Under certain conditions, nonwhite lawmakers are also more likely to support race-related bills and secure earmarks that enhance the substantive representation of nonwhite constituencies (Kerr and Miller 1997; Canon 1999; Whitby 2000; Haynie 2001; Tate 2004; Grose et al. 2007; Grose 2011; Clark 2019).¹ Nonwhite lawmakers also advance nonwhite interests through congressional oversight (Minta 2011), contact with executive agencies (Lowande et al. 2019), and constituency service (Broockman 2013), and by

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increasing access for racially focused interest groups to committees (Minta 2021).

Less is known, however, about whether nonwhite representation also shapes the behavior of white lawmakers. In this paper, I examine how the racial diversity of committees in the U.S. House of Representatives influences legislators' discussions of race in hearings and affects the advancement and passage of race-related legislation. Committees provide a useful setting for examining this possibility because nonwhite representation varies widely across committees, creating different opportunities for white and nonwhite lawmakers to interact. I argue that, in racially diverse committees, repeated interaction between white and nonwhite legislators may lead white Democrats to develop race-related expertise from their nonwhite colleagues. To test this argument, I combine large-scale text classification with a detailed content analysis of more than 11,000 race-related committee hearing statements and 87,000 full bill texts introduced in the U.S. House of Representatives from the 105th to the 117th Congresses.

Leveraging a within-legislator identification strategy, I find that white Democrats on racially diverse committees are more likely to cite evidence when discussing race than they are on predominantly white committees. White Democrats on racially diverse committees are also more likely to cite the same sources of evidence in the second half of a term that nonwhite lawmakers on the same committee cited in the first half. Across several additional tests, I find that this pattern is consistent with a learning mechanism. Finally, I show that race-based expertise is associated with substantive representation: legislators who more frequently cite evidence when discussing race are more effective at advancing race-related legislation.

These findings advance scholarship on descriptive and substantive representation in two key ways. First, they add an identity-specific dimension to theories of information exchange in legislative committees. Existing work shows that committees are central sites for acquiring and exchanging policy expertise (Fenno 1973; Krehbiel 1992; Curry 2019; Ban et al. 2023). My results suggest that committees also transmit race-related expertise, and that this transmission depends on the racial composition of the committee. This extends existing accounts of committee learning by showing that information exchange is not only institutional, but also interpersonal and, in this case, cross-racial. Second, I show that race-based expertise is associated with success in advancing race-related legislation. Scholars have long debated whether and under what conditions descriptive representation facilitates substantive representation (Canon 1999; Tate 2004; Minta 2011, 2021). My results indicate that race-related expertise developed by white Democrats in racially diverse committees may be one indirect mechanism through which descriptive representation translates into substantive representation.

1 | Race-Based Contact Effects, Learning, and Evidence Use in Committees

Existing scholarship identifies several factors that shape whether race is discussed or considered in committee. Racially

diverse committees devote more attention to race-related issues (Ellis and Wilson 2013; Minta and Sinclair-Chapman 2013; Nestor 2023), and in racially salient hearings, Black and Latino legislators participate more than their white colleagues (Gamble 2007; Minta 2009; Rouse 2023). Nonwhite legislators are also more likely to discuss race across hearing topics, and white lawmakers are more likely to do so in racially diverse committees (Lollis 2025). Race may also appear more frequently on the agenda when a committee's jurisdiction directly encompasses race-related issues (Minta and Sinclair-Chapman 2013; Ellis and Wilson 2013). Finally, the informational environment may shape whether race is discussed since witnesses and staff influence the information legislators encounter in committee (Ban et al. 2023).²

What remains less clear, however, is whether committee racial diversity shapes how white lawmakers engage race-related issues once race enters committee deliberation. I focus on this question by examining whether repeated interaction with nonwhite colleagues shapes white lawmakers' use of evidence when discussing race. There are several reasons to expect white lawmakers to cite evidence more frequently when discussing race in racially diverse committees. Intergroup contact theory suggests that repeated contact with nonwhite colleagues may alter white lawmakers' behavior, particularly when members interact as peers, pursue shared goals, and operate within rules that structure participation (Allport et al. 1954; Pettigrew 1998). Legislative committees approximate several of these conditions: members interact repeatedly, work within common policy jurisdictions, and participate in highly structured settings (Lollis 2025). Committees are also information-rich institutions designed to transmit policy-relevant knowledge and expertise (Krehbiel 1992; Battaglini et al. 2019; Curry 2019; Ban et al. 2023). Thus, while I do not argue that committee interactions change legislators' underlying attitudes, repeated interaction with nonwhite colleagues in racially diverse committees may shape how white lawmakers substantiate race-related claims.

One mechanism through which cross-group contact in racially diverse committees may influence white lawmakers' statements is learning (Allport et al. 1954; Pettigrew 1998). Because committees are designed to transmit policy-relevant information (Krehbiel 1992; Battaglini et al. 2019; Curry 2019), hearings repeatedly expose members to colleagues' expertise through their statements and questions. As a result, nonwhite legislators' statements, policy frames, and evidence use may introduce white lawmakers to race-related knowledge they might otherwise lack (Mansbridge 1999). If white lawmakers learn from their nonwhite colleagues in these settings, they may increasingly cite evidence when discussing race.

Contact effects, however, are unlikely to influence all white lawmakers equally. Cross-group contact is most effective when individuals interact as peers and pursue common goals (Pettigrew 1998). Because most nonwhite legislators are Democrats (Griffin 2014) and congressional parties are increasingly internally homogeneous (Lee 2016), white Democrats are more likely than white Republicans to share partisan ties, equal status, and policy objectives with nonwhite members. Democrats are also more likely to support racially progressive

policies (Grose 2011), suggesting that they may be more open to learning from nonwhite lawmakers than Republicans. If contact fosters learning, then white Democrats serving on racially diverse committees should be especially likely to change how they use evidence when discussing race.

I test my argument by examining several observable implications. The first concerns the *frequency* of evidence use. If racially diverse committees expose white Democrats to nonwhite colleagues' evidence use, then white Democrats on racially diverse committees should cite evidence more often in their race-related remarks than white Democrats on predominantly white committees.³

H1. (*Frequency of Evidence-Based Race Statements*): *The likelihood that a white Democrat makes evidence-based race statements in hearings is positively associated with the racial diversity of a committee.*

A second implication of my argument concerns the *content* of white Democrats' evidence use. If white Democrats learn from nonwhite colleagues in racially diverse committees, they should not only cite evidence more frequently; they should also draw on some of the same sources that nonwhite lawmakers use to substantiate race-related claims. Nonwhite lawmakers may bring race-related expertise to committee deliberation because they draw on lived experiences and identity-based knowledge when engaging race-related issues. White lawmakers, who likely have less race-related expertise, may view nonwhite colleagues as authoritative on these issues (Mansbridge 1999; Minta 2011, 2021). As a result, exposure to nonwhite colleagues in racially diverse committees may expand the sources white Democrats use to make race-related arguments.⁴ If white Democrats are learning from nonwhite colleagues, then as committee racial diversity increases, they should be more likely to cite in the second half of a term the same sources of evidence that nonwhite committee members cited in the first half of the term.

H2. (*Content of Evidence-Based Race Statements*): *As a committee's racial diversity increases, white Democrats are more likely to cite in the second half of a term the same sources of evidence that nonwhite committee members cited in the first half of the term.*

These expectations are consistent with the idea that white Democrats learn from nonwhite lawmakers. Yet the same-term patterns in H1 and H2 cannot, by themselves, distinguish learning from several alternative mechanisms. Three alternative explanations are especially relevant: strategic adaptation, in which white Democrats adjust their statements to appeal to nonwhite colleagues or signal attentiveness to race-related concerns without learning new information; shared informational exposure, in which members cite the same sources because they encounter the same witnesses, staff briefings, party materials, or committee documents rather than because of the committee's racial diversity (Burgat et al. 2020; Gaynor 2025); and committee norms, in which racially diverse committees make evidence-based race speech more expected, useful, or rewarding.

To better distinguish learning from these alternative explanations, I examine whether earlier exposure to racially diverse committees predicts later evidence use. If white Democrats

learn from nonwhite colleagues, then the effects of that exposure should not be confined to the term in which contact occurs. Instead, white Democrats who served on more racially diverse committees in the prior term should continue to draw on race-related evidence in the current term, even after accounting for current committee diversity. This test differs from H1 and H2, which examine same-term evidence use and source matching. In contrast, H3 evaluates whether greater racial diversity on a legislator's committee in the prior term ($t-1$) predicts more evidence-based race statements in the current term (t), even after controlling for current committee diversity.

H3. (*Prior Committee Diversity and Subsequent Evidence Use*): *Among white Democrats who serve on the same committee in consecutive terms, greater racial diversity on that committee in the previous term ($t-1$) will be associated with more evidence-based race statements in the current term (t), even after controlling for the committee's current racial diversity.*

Finally, I examine the consequences of race-based expertise for substantive representation. Frequent evidence use when discussing race reflects a form of race-based expertise that may help legislators advance race-related legislation. This question is important because substantive representation depends not only on whether legislators discuss race, but also on whether they can translate race-related expertise into policy success. Although I do not expect a single evidence citation in a committee hearing to affect whether a race bill passes the House, I do expect legislators who consistently cite evidence when discussing race to be more successful at advancing the race bills they sponsor.

This expectation follows from work on legislative effectiveness and policy expertise. Legislators with race-based expertise should be both more knowledgeable about race-related policy and more motivated to advance it. More generally, legislative effectiveness is closely tied to experience, expertise, and influence: members who have spent decades in the House, attained leadership positions, and developed specialized policy agendas are more effective than their peers (Volden and Wiseman 2014, 2020). Rank-and-file legislators also look to issue experts when deciding whether to support legislation (Curry 2015). Thus, if evidence use captures race-based expertise, legislators who frequently cite evidence when discussing race should be more effective at advancing their sponsored race bills, but no more effective than their peers at advancing legislation unrelated to race.

H4. (*Race-Based Expertise and Substantive Representation*): *Legislators who more frequently cite evidence when discussing race are more effective at advancing race-related bills.*

2 | Measuring Evidence in Committee Hearing Statements

I measure evidence use in legislators' committee hearing statements because hearings are both directly observable and central to the development of legislative expertise. Existing research treats hearing statements as meaningful legislative behavior: they capture deliberation (Kathlene 1994; Ban et al. 2022; Miller and Sutherland 2023; Boyd et al. 2025), hearing agendas and policy

attention (Sheingate 2006; Minta and Sinclair-Chapman 2013; Esterling 2011), policy framing (Ban and Kaslovsky 2025; Lewallen et al. 2024), and information use and acquisition (Ban et al. 2024). Hearing statements also reveal how legislators define problems, justify policy claims, and signal which arguments and sources they regard as authoritative in committee deliberation (Lewallen et al. 2024; Ban et al. 2023; Park 2021). Unlike floor speeches, committee hearings are closely tied to policy development and expertise building (Kiewiet 1991; Krehbiel 1992; Battaglini et al. 2019). Legislators encounter information in hearings through witness testimony (Ban et al. 2024), committee staff (Ommundsen 2023; Fong et al. 2025), lobbyists (Ban et al. 2023), party leaders (Gaynor 2025), and experienced colleagues (Curry 2019). For these reasons, hearing statements offer a useful way to assess whether legislators cite evidence to support race-related claims.

At the same time, legislators may not always prioritize acquiring or citing evidence, even in committee. Although legislators rely on information to decide how to vote, when to collaborate, and whether to compromise (Krehbiel 1992; Curry 2015), gathering relevant evidence requires substantial time and resources—both of which are scarce in an overburdened Congress (LaPira et al. 2020). And the benefits of doing so are also not always obvious: in a polarized environment, grandstanding in hearings can be more strategically advantageous than citing evidence (Park 2021), especially because voters often reward such behavior (Park 2023). Thus, although evidence is central to committee work, its actual use may be relatively modest. If evidence is used infrequently, it is all the more important to understand the conditions under which legislators substantiate their discussions of race with evidence.

Despite the importance of understanding whether legislators cite evidence in committee hearings, measuring such behavior poses serious challenges. Given the length and volume of committee hearing transcripts, existing research analyzing committee statements typically follows one of two methodological approaches: (1) content analysis of a limited number of hearings within a small set of committees in a single congressional term (Gamble 2007, 2011); or (2) automated coding using classification and machine learning methods (Park 2021, 2023; Lewallen et al. 2024; Lollis 2025; Ban et al. 2026). Content analyses of this kind allow scholars to create detailed, highly accurate measures, but they are often so time intensive that the resulting findings are limited to a specific committee or term, which may represent a non-random sample of the broader corpus. Classification and machine learning methods address this limitation by coding a much larger volume of statements, but they can struggle to identify complex and multidimensional latent concepts and, as a result, often produce less accurate measures than hand coding.

I employ a measurement strategy that combines large-scale classification with content analysis to address both limitations. Since my theory focuses on how legislators use evidence when discussing race, I systematically identify race-based statements from all committee hearings over a 26-year period using classification methods. By systematically identifying all race-related statements in congressional committee hearings, I mitigate concerns about non-random sampling and term- or committee-specific findings. I then conduct a detailed and systematic

content analysis of each race statement to determine whether it cites evidence. By manually coding each statement, I produce precise and valid measures that capture not only whether a statement cites evidence but also the specific source referenced.

3 | Data & Methods

I analyze transcripts from more than 16,000 U.S. House committee hearings held between the 105th and 117th Congresses. The hearing transcripts were scraped from [govinfo.gov](https://www.govinfo.gov) and parsed into individual legislator statements using an algorithm that identifies speaker names and matches them to GovTrack identifiers. The resulting statements were then manually reviewed to verify that each was matched to the correct legislator.⁵ The unit of analysis is the individual legislator statement, which I define as a single uninterrupted speaking turn by a legislator in a hearing transcript. I exclude witness statements, opening statements, and evidence submitted for the record. The resulting dataset includes 1,410,292 statements by 1,164 unique members across 24 committees. On average, legislators made 11 statements per hearing, and the average statement length is 96 words.

To identify race-based hearing statements, I used a bigram dictionary classifier. To build the dictionary, I hand-coded a training set of 5,000 statements randomly sampled from the full corpus of hearing statements, labeling each for whether it contained a racial reference. From the race statements present in the training set, I extracted 536 race-related bigrams—two-word pairs that reference race either broadly (e.g., “people of color,” “racial minority”) or by naming specific groups (e.g., Black, Asian). I then applied this dictionary to the full corpus. If a corpus statement contained at least one race bigram, it was coded as a race statement. The method accurately identified race-based hearing statements in a validation set comparing hand-coded and bigram-labeled classifications (AUC = 0.9, κ = 0.87). Of the 1.4 million committee hearing statements, 11,860 referenced race. On average, legislators made 14 race statements per term, with an average length of 300 words.⁶

To measure evidence use, I conducted a detailed and systematic content analysis of all 11,860 race statements to determine whether they cite a credible source to substantiate a claim and, if so, the specific source referenced. I define evidence use as a legislator citing a credible source to substantiate a race-related claim. This definition is broader than a narrow conception of empirical or statistical evidence. It includes empirical sources, such as Census Bureau data, academic studies, and agency reports, but it also includes legal and policy authorities, such as legislation, administrative rules, and court decisions, when legislators use those sources to support race-related claims. For example, when a legislator cites *Shelby County v. Holder* to support a claim about voting rights protections, or cites the Voting Rights Act to substantiate a claim about federal civil-rights enforcement, I treat those references as evidence because the legislator is using an external authority to support a claim rather than merely asserting it, even though the source is not empirical or statistical.⁷ Credible sources include materials produced by government, academic, journalistic, legal, or expert entities. Under this definition, legislators cited the following source types most frequently: executive branch reports and rules (35%), legislation

TABLE 1 | Coding evidence-based race statements.

Coding decision	Source	Race statement
Evidence statement	Census Bureau	“During the last census count in 2010, the Census Bureau found that <i>African Americans were under-counted by over 800,000.</i> ”
Non-evidence statement	—	“During the last census count in 2010, <i>African Americans were under-counted by over 800,000.</i> ”
Non-evidence statement	—	“I’m deeply concerned that African Americans are being undercounted in the Census. Does the Bureau have a goal or plan to improve the Black undercount and increase participation?”

Note: Examples are based on a statement made by Representative Steven Horsford (D-NV) in an Oversight Committee hearing in the 116th Congress.

(32%), witness testimony (8%), interest group reports (7%), court rulings (4%), news articles (4%), and academic scholarship (3%).

My definition of evidence is theoretically distinct from personal experience. Existing work demonstrates that legislators’ personal backgrounds and lived experiences shape their behavior as representatives (e.g., Burden 2007). Those experiences may reflect early life, education, health, or prior occupations, and thus shape legislators’ issue priorities once in Congress. Unlike those prior experiences, which were formative before legislators entered office, evidence is typically sought out and cited during legislative service. Although legislators’ experiences certainly shape their behavior, evidence usage is a more appropriate measure for testing my argument because it captures a form of acquired knowledge that may emerge through interactions with colleagues in committee hearings.

I also do not analyze witness statements. Instead, the dataset includes only statements made by legislators. My theory proposes that repeated and sustained contact between white Democrats and nonwhite legislators may lead white Democrats to use more evidence when discussing race. Because witnesses often appear in only a single hearing, repeated and sustained contact does not occur frequently between legislators and witnesses.⁸

I coded legislators’ statements that met these criteria as evidence statements and extracted both the source category (e.g., court case) and the specific source (e.g., *Shelby County v. Holder*). Statements that relied on unsupported claims or made no claim were coded as non-evidence statements. This approach is conservative by design and may undercount cases in which a source is implied by context or mentioned by the legislator earlier in the hearing. Still, merely making a claim is not sufficient to classify a statement as evidence-based: without an explicit citation, it is unclear whether the claim is grounded in evidence or simply asserted. As a result, the measure should be interpreted as a lower-bound estimate of evidence usage rather than an exhaustive measure of all evidence-informed discussion.

Table 1 illustrates the coding decisions associated with three variations of the same race statement. I coded the first statement as evidence-based because it cites a source—the Census Bureau—to support a claim (i.e., African Americans were undercounted in the Census). The second version is not coded as evidence-based because it lacks a citation. The third neither cites a source nor makes a claim. Although misclassification is less of a concern because I manually read and coded all statements,

Section 2 of the appendix assesses the measure’s face validity and confirms that it accurately captures evidence usage.

After determining whether each race statement cited evidence, I created two dependent variables. The first, **Evidence**, is a count of the total number of evidence-based race statements a legislator makes in each committee-term.⁹ This variable ranges from 0 to 19, with a mean of 1.05. The second variable, **Matching Sources**, is a count of the number of unique sources that a white lawmaker cites in the second half of a congressional term that were cited by any nonwhite lawmaker serving on the same committee in the first half of that term. For example, suppose that during the first half of the 117th Congress, nonwhite members of the House Judiciary Committee cite *Shelby County v. Holder*, the Voting Rights Advancement Act, and the Census Bureau. If a white Judiciary member cites those same three sources during the second half of the term, that member receives a value of 3. Because the unit of analysis is the legislator–committee-term, this is not a dyadic measure linking a white member to a particular nonwhite member. Instead, it captures whether white legislators’ later-term citations draw on the set of sources introduced in committee discourse by nonwhite members earlier in the same term. **Matching Sources** ranges from 0 to 3, with a mean of 0.475.

Because both variables are right-skewed, I transform each by adding one and taking the natural log to better approximate a normal distribution. After this transformation, **Evidence** ranges from 0 to 2.996, with a mean of 0.50, and **Matching Sources** ranges from 0 to 2.2, with a mean of 0.75. I use the logged versions of both dependent variables in all in-text models.¹⁰

4 | Results

4.1 | Descriptive Findings

Although evidence-based race statements are somewhat more common during Democratic majorities (110th, 111th, 116th, and 117th Congresses), variation across terms is minimal. Table 2 shows that legislators make, on average, one to two evidence-based race statements per term. And while the total number of evidence-based race statements per term is modest, approximately half of legislators in the dataset make at least one in a given term (see Table 2, column 4). In most terms, more than 60% of Democrats make at least one evidence-based race statement (see Table 2, column 5). In the 110th Congress, for

TABLE 2 | Average number of evidence-based race statements per term.

Term	Party in majority	Mean evidence-based race statements per legislator	% of legislators making at least one evidence-based race statement	% of democrats making at least one evidence-based race statement	Range
105 (1997)	R	0.698	47.2%	63%	0–3
106 (1999)	R	0.902	49.6%	51.9%	0–15
107 (2001)	R	1.32	66.3%	69.8%	0–11
108 (2003)	R	1.71	62.4%	70.3%	0–11
109 (2005)	R	1.79	62.2%	70.9%	0–14
110 (2007)	D	2.07	65.7%	71.7%	0–23
111 (2009)	D	1.81	60.7%	67.4%	0–21
112 (2011)	R	1.35	58.2%	69.9%	0–11
113 (2013)	R	0.970	48.8%	55.1%	0–7
114 (2015)	R	1.13	56.1%	61.5%	0–10
115 (2017)	R	0.742	46.2%	59.8%	0–6
116 (2019)	D	1.55	51.6%	56.8%	0–19
117 (2021)	D	1.44	52.3%	59.6%	0–21

Note: Evidence-based race statements are infrequent, though a majority of legislators—particularly Democrats—make at least one per term. Table 2 includes the mean number of evidence-based race statements made by each legislator across all terms and the average maximum and minimum value per term. Column 4 displays the percentage of legislators making at least one evidence-based race statement per term. Column 5 reports the percentage of Democrats making at least one evidence-based race statement per term.

example, two-thirds of all legislators and nearly three-quarters of Democrats made at least one evidence-based race statement. Together, these patterns suggest that evidence usage in discussions of race is modest in absolute terms, but not limited to a small set of lawmakers.

Evidence-based race statements occur across all committees, though their prevalence varies. The highest shares of race statements that include evidence appear in the Education (35.3%), Natural Resources (31.0%), Judiciary (30.4%), Ways and Means (28.3%), and Financial Services (27.5%) Committees. Descriptively, these committees span several policy domains in which race-related issues often arise in congressional debate, including education and labor policy, tribal affairs and environmental justice, civil rights and immigration, taxation and social welfare, and housing, banking, and consumer finance. Although evidence-based race statements are concentrated in certain committees, these descriptive patterns do not by themselves explain the relationship between committee racial diversity and evidence-based race statements.

Evidence-based race statements are also not distributed evenly across members: nonwhite and Democratic lawmakers consistently make more evidence-based race statements than their white and Republican colleagues. Figure 1 plots the average number of evidence-based race statements per term by lawmakers' race and party. Each dot represents an individual lawmaker, with blue dots indicating Democrats and red dots indicating Republicans. On average, nonwhite legislators make nearly two evidence-based race statements per term, compared to fewer than one for white legislators.¹¹ While this difference

may appear modest, it is substantively meaningful given that the overall average is only about one evidence-based race statement per term.

Figure 1 also highlights a strong partisan divide: Democrats—regardless of race—are more likely than Republicans to incorporate evidence when discussing race. Nonwhite Democrats, for instance, make one and a half more evidence-based race statements per term than nonwhite Republicans. Notably, the nonwhite lawmakers most likely to cite evidence are all women of color, which is consistent with existing research showing that Black women often collaborate to highlight racial and gender issues (Brown 2014). Ayanna Pressley (D-MA) and Rashida Tlaib (D-MI) made more than ten evidence-based race statements per term, while Sylvia Garcia (D-TX), Debra Haaland (D-NM), and Cori Bush (D-MO) made more than five. Among white lawmakers, Democrats were most likely to reference evidence—an exception being Rick Renzi (R-AZ), who represented the Navajo Nation and Hopi Reservation.

4.2 | Model Estimation

4.2.1 | White Democrats Cite More Evidence on Diverse Committees

To estimate the relationship between committee racial diversity and evidence-based race statements, I exploit within-legislator variation across committees using legislator and term fixed effects. These models account for time-invariant member characteristics and unobserved factors that vary across congressional

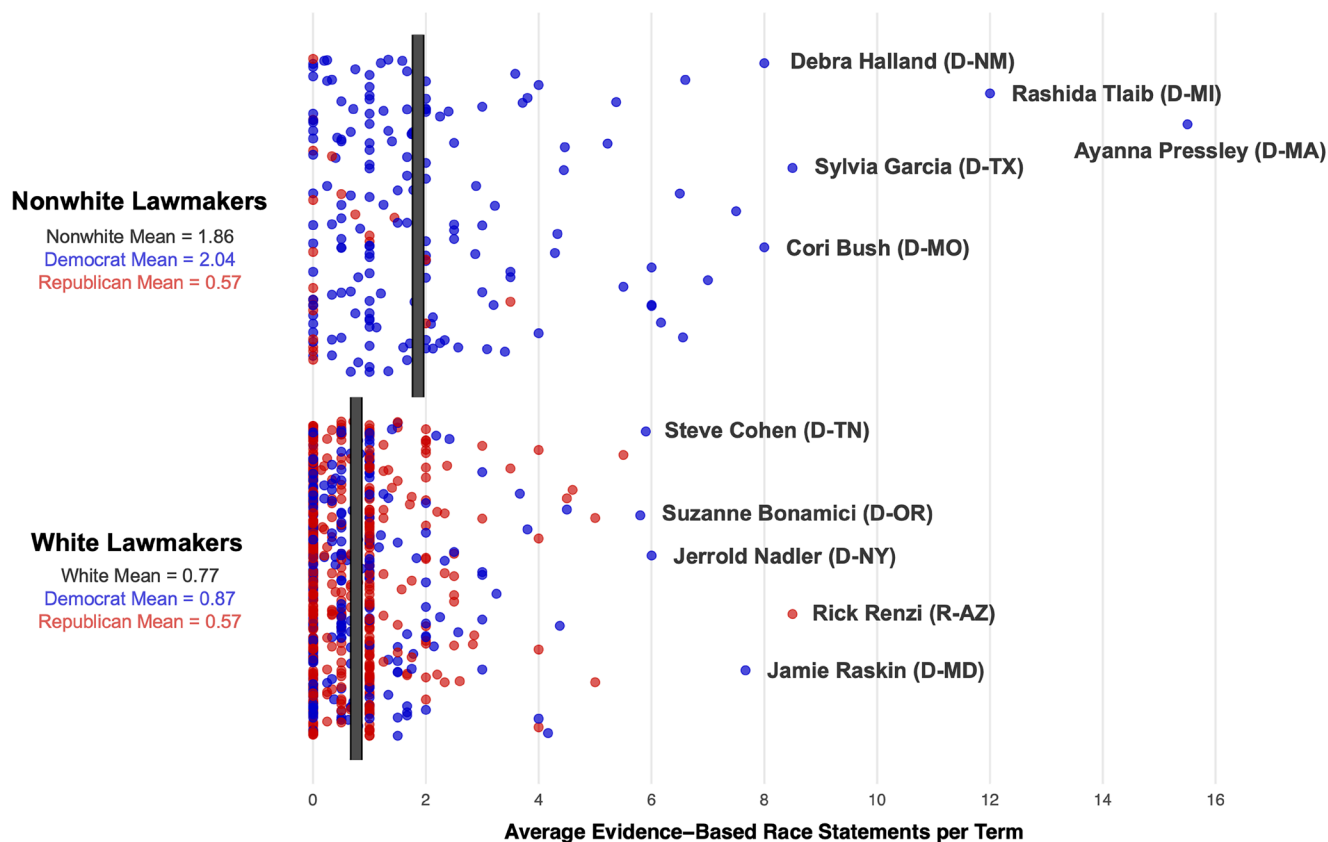


FIGURE 1 | Average Evidence-Based Race Statements By Race and Party. Each dot in the jitter plot represents a unique lawmaker and indicates their average number of evidence-based race statements made per term. Blue dots indicate Democrats; red dots represent Republicans. The solid gray line indicates the mean value for each panel. Nonwhite lawmakers, on average, make one additional evidence-based race statement per term compared to white lawmakers. Democrats, on average, make more such statements than Republicans. This finding remains robust in a multivariate model with member-level controls and term fixed effects (see Appendix Table 4.3).

terms. As a result, identification comes from changes in the racial composition of a legislator's committees. I do not include committee fixed effects because the key predictor—the share of nonwhite members on each committee—varies at the committee level. Instead, I control for whether a committee is a power committee (Appropriations, Ways and Means, Budget, and Judiciary) and for whether the committee's *primary* jurisdiction encompasses race-related issues, particularly civil rights and minority issues, social welfare, and Native American affairs (Minta and Sinclair-Chapman 2013; Ellis and Wilson 2013; Minta 2009). Using this definition, I classify Judiciary, Ways and Means, and Natural Resources as race-jurisdiction committees.¹² I also control for two additional committee-level features—the number of hearings held and the number of bills referred in a term—that proxy for workload and the breadth of committee jurisdiction. Under this specification, the estimates are identified net of stable differences across legislators, committee jurisdiction, and common changes across congressional terms.¹³

To test my first hypothesis, I estimate three OLS regression models with legislator and term fixed effects.¹⁴ Table 3 reports the results. The dependent variable is **Evidence**. In Column 1, the dependent variable is the natural log of the total number of evidence-based race statements made by white legislators in each committee-term. Columns 2 and 3 estimate the same model separately for white Democrats and white Republicans,

respectively. The independent variable of interest is the proportion of nonwhite lawmakers on each committee (0–1).¹⁵ Standard errors are robust and clustered by legislator.¹⁶

Model estimates indicate that white lawmakers make more evidence-based race statements as the proportion of nonwhite lawmakers on their committee increases ($\beta = 0.69$; $p = 0.00$). As expected, however, the coefficient is largest in models subset to only white Democrats, who are most likely to meet the conditions necessary for contact effects ($\beta = 1.01$; $p = 0.01$). In substantive terms, the models predict that a 10 percentage point increase in nonwhite committee membership is associated with a 10.6% increase in the number of evidence-based race statements made by white Democrats. Although this estimated change is modest in absolute terms, it is meaningful because evidence-based race speech is uncommon: nonwhite lawmakers make roughly two evidence-based race statements per term, and many white members make none. Against that baseline, the model-implied increase of one additional evidence-based race statement per term for white Democrats on highly diverse committees represents a meaningful behavioral shift. In models restricted to white Republicans, the coefficient is not statistically significant.

This relationship is independent of factors that differ across white lawmakers and of changes across congressional terms. It is also not driven by whether the committee is powerful, falls

TABLE 3 | White Democrats make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees.

	Evidence (white lawmaker)	Evidence (white democrat)	Evidence (white republican)
	1	2	3
Proportion of nonwhite legislators on committee	0.686** (0.266)	1.006* (0.404)	0.428 (0.381)
Power committee	0.134* (0.057)	0.159 [†] (0.097)	0.124* (0.063)
Race committee	0.011 (0.051)	−0.112 (0.077)	0.138* (0.062)
No. of Hearings	0.001** (0.0004)	0.002* (0.001)	0.001 [†] (0.001)
No. of Bills Referred	0.0001* (0.0001)	0.0002* (0.0001)	0.00001 (0.0001)
Intercept	0.353** (0.131)	0.013 (0.162)	0.378* (0.161)
Legislator Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓
Term Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓
R ²	0.443	0.445	0.457
Adjusted R ²	0.149	0.206	0.094
Observations	1935	875	1060

Note: White Democrats cite more race-based evidence statements as the percentage of nonwhite lawmakers on their committees increases. The dependent variable is the natural log of the total number of evidence-based statements made by a white lawmaker in a given committee-term ($DV = \ln(\text{Evidence} + 1)$). Standard errors are robust and clustered by legislator. Alternative specifications, including models with full controls, are reported in Appendix 3.1. Bold values indicate the primary coefficients of interest.

[†] $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

within a race-related jurisdiction, holds more hearings, or has more bills referred to it. The results presented in Table 3 remain robust across several alternative specifications, including models that drop legislator fixed effects, include full controls, use the proportion of evidence-based race statements out of total race statements as the dependent variable, and use the non-logged dependent variable. Importantly, I also show that committee diversity does not predict greater evidence usage among white Democrats in non-race statements (see Appendix Section 9). This suggests that, as expected, the relationship between committee racial diversity and evidence usage among white Democrats is specific to discussions of race.¹⁷

The main results in Table 3 are also robust to tests addressing three alternative explanations raised in the theory section: committee selection, race-relevant jurisdiction, and shared informational environments. To address committee selection, I estimate

two “stayers” models: one restricting the sample to legislators who remain on the same committee for at least three consecutive terms, and another restricting the sample to the first committee on which each legislator served for three consecutive terms (Appendix Tables 7.1 and 7.3). I also exclude first-term legislators, who are most likely to sort into race-relevant committees (Appendix Table 7.2). Across these tests, which hold committee assignment more constant and reduce the likelihood that the results are driven by legislators selecting into committees based on preexisting race-related expertise, the coefficient for white Democrats remains positive and statistically significant.

I also examine whether the results are driven primarily by statements made in race-relevant committees. In addition to controlling for whether a committee's jurisdiction is race-related in the main models, I include a lagged measure of the total number of race statements made in each committee-term (Appendix Table 8.1) and re-estimate the model separately within the Judiciary and Oversight Committees (Appendix Table 8.2).¹⁸ The results in these models are consistent. Finally, to address the possibility that racially diverse committees simply have more durable race-related informational environments, I control for the lagged number of unique race-related sources cited in the committee in the prior term (Appendix Table 8.3). This accounts for whether some committees already had richer race-related source environments before the current term, independent of their current racial composition. The results remain consistent with the in-text models for white Democrats ($\beta = 0.99$; $p = 0.02$). Together, these tests reduce concerns that the main findings are driven solely by committee selection, race-relevant jurisdiction, or shared informational exposure.

4.2.2 | Legislators Cite Similar Sources of Evidence on Diverse Committees

My second hypothesis posits that contact effects should also prompt white lawmakers on diverse committees to cite the same sources of evidence as their nonwhite colleagues. To test this expectation, I pair descriptive evidence from two committees—the Education and Labor Committee and the Judiciary Committee in the 116th Congress—with estimates from within-legislator OLS regression models. I use these committees to illustrate the source-matching logic for two reasons. First, they vary in racial composition: about one-fourth of Education and Labor members are nonwhite—roughly the House average—compared to nearly 40% of Judiciary Committee members. Second, both committees play a significant role in policymaking, oversee consequential policy jurisdictions, and frequently engage in discussions about race.

Consistent with my expectation, white and nonwhite legislators frequently cited the same sources of evidence on the Judiciary Committee (the Department of Justice, the Equality Act, *Shelby County v. Holder*, and the FBI), but not on the Education and Labor Committee (see Table 4). Indeed, *Brown v. Board of Education* was the only overlapping source cited by both white and nonwhite members on the Education and Labor Committee throughout the term. This pattern, of course, does not suggest that lawmakers on less diverse committees cite irrelevant or unimportant sources. Both white and nonwhite legislators in the

TABLE 4 | Similar source citations on committees with average and high % of nonwhite lawmakers.

Education and labor (116th Congress)		Judiciary (116th congress)	
24% nonwhite legislators on committee (average)		39% nonwhite legislators on committee (high)	
Top sources nonwhite lawmakers	Top sources white lawmakers	Top sources nonwhite lawmakers	Top sources white lawmakers
Brown v. Board	Brown v. Board	DOJ	DOJ
Paycheck Fairness Act	Civil Rights Act	Equality Act	Equality Act
DOL	Equal Pay Act	Shelby County v. Holder	Shelby County v. Holder
Brookings	Government Accountability Office	FBI	FBI
Commonwealth Fund	Affordable Care Act	Pew	Voting Rights Act
Fair Labor Standards Act	AFL-CIO	Commission to Study Reparations	SUCCESS Act
Federal Reserve	America's College Promise Act	Local Law Enforcement Hate Crimes Prevention Act	Bend the Arc
Maternal CARE Act	Bridge Magazine	National Institute of Standards and Technology	Census Bureau
Religious Freedom Restoration Act	Bureau of Labor Statistics	Social Security Act	Center for Police Equity

Note: White and nonwhite lawmakers are more likely to cite the same sources on the Judiciary committee (39% nonwhite lawmakers) than the Education and Labor committee (24% nonwhite lawmakers). The table reports the nine sources most frequently cited by white and nonwhite lawmakers on two committees in the 116th Congress.

Education and Labor Committee frequently referenced significant and timely evidence, including the Civil Rights Act, the Affordable Care Act, and the Fair Labor Standards Act. Instead, the finding suggests that racial diversity within a committee influences the type of evidence white lawmakers cite.

To test this expectation more directly, I estimate whether white lawmakers cite, later in a term, sources that nonwhite lawmakers on the same committee cited earlier in that same term. The dependent variable, **Matching Sources**, is the natural log of the number of unique sources cited by a white lawmaker in the second half of a term that also appear in the set of sources cited by nonwhite lawmakers on the same committee in the first half of the term.¹⁹ This temporal structure is important: rather than measuring whether white and nonwhite lawmakers cite the same sources at any point in the term, the measure captures whether white lawmakers' later evidence use draws on sources that had already appeared in race-related committee discourse among nonwhite members.

The key independent variable is the committee's proportion of nonwhite members. I estimate three OLS regression models with legislator and term fixed effects and the same committee-specific controls used above. To account for the possibility that matching increases mechanically as more sources are cited, I control for both the total number of unique sources cited by nonwhite lawmakers in the first half of the term and the total

number of unique sources cited by the white lawmaker in the second half of the term.

The results reported in Table 5 indicate that white Democrats serving on committees with a higher share of nonwhite members are more likely to cite, in the second half of the term, sources that nonwhite committee members cited in the first half. This relationship is positive and statistically significant for white Democrats ($\beta = 0.39$; $p = 0.05$), but not for white Republicans ($\beta = 0.10$; $p = 0.59$). Substantively, moving from a predominantly white committee to a racially diverse committee is associated with a shift from zero to one matching source, which, given the range of the variable (0–3), represents a meaningful change in which evidence white Democrats choose to invoke when discussing race.

One concern, addressed in the previous model and especially relevant here, is that source matching between white and nonwhite lawmakers may reflect a committee's shared informational environment rather than information exchange between legislators. Committees that hold more hearings provide more opportunities for legislators to encounter the same witness testimony, staff briefings, committee materials, and other sources of policy information. As a result, it is possible that white Democrats cite more matching sources because the same race-related information is available rather than because of contact with nonwhite lawmakers in racially diverse committees.

TABLE 5 | Nonwhite and White Legislators Cite Similar Sources on Racially Diverse Committees.

	Matching sources (white lawmakers)	Matching sources (white democrats)	Matching sources (white republicans)
	1	2	3
Proportion of nonwhite lawmakers on committee	0.243[†] (0.140)	0.392* (0.200)	0.102 (0.189)
Total race statements	−0.006* (0.003)	−0.005 (0.004)	−0.006 (0.005)
Total nonwhite unique sources (1st half of term)	0.004* (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.006** (0.002)
Total white unique sources (2nd half of term)	0.327*** (0.016)	0.294*** (0.025)	0.362*** (0.018)
Power committee	−0.040 [†] (0.021)	−0.044 (0.029)	−0.049 (0.034)
Race committee	0.022 (0.023)	0.028 (0.032)	0.006 (0.035)
No. of hearings	0.00004 (0.0002)	0.0001 (0.0002)	−0.00002 (0.0002)
No. of bills referred	0.00001 (0.00003)	0.00003 (0.00004)	0.00002 (0.00004)
Intercept	−0.346*** (0.074)	0.171** (0.062)	−0.407*** (0.100)
Legislator fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
Term fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
R^2	0.710	0.686	0.744
Adjusted R^2	0.556	0.549	0.570
Observations	1935	875	1060

Note: White Democrats on more racially diverse committees are more likely to cite, in the second half of a term, the same evidence sources that nonwhite committee members cited earlier in the term. The dependent variable is the natural log of the total number of sources cited by white lawmakers that were also cited by nonwhite lawmakers in a committee-term. Standard errors are robust and clustered by legislator. Alternative specifications, including models with full controls, are reported in Appendix 3.2. Bold values indicate the primary coefficients of interest.

[†] $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

However, the model estimates provide little support for this explanation. In the white Democrat model, a 10 percentage-point increase in nonwhite committee membership is associated with approximately a 4.0% increase in matching sources. In contrast, the number of hearings covariate is not statistically significant, and its magnitude is negligible: 10 additional hearings, which represent 10 additional opportunities to encounter committee-specific information, are associated with only a 0.1% increase in matching sources. Thus, while formal committee activity may create opportunities for information acquisition, the results suggest that the racial composition of the committee is more strongly associated with whether white Democrats cite sources previously introduced by nonwhite colleagues.

Another concern is that white Democrats may simply add sources cited by nonwhite lawmakers to their citation

repertoires, rather than shift the overall composition of the sources they cite. This pattern would still be consistent with my argument: white Democrats may learn from nonwhite lawmakers by incorporating additional race-relevant sources into their statements about race. A more demanding test, however, is whether white Democrats' citation portfolios shift away from sources not previously cited by nonwhite lawmakers. To assess this possibility, I report an additional specification using **Non-Matching Sources**—defined as the number of unique sources a white member cites in the second half of a term that do not appear in the first-half nonwhite source set—as the dependent variable. If white legislators' non-matching sources decline as committee diversity increases, this pattern is consistent with a reallocation in citation choices: white Democrats' second-half citation portfolios shift toward sources previously referenced by nonwhite colleagues rather than simply expanding to include

additional sources. Appendix Table 4.9 demonstrates that white Democrats' non-matching sources decrease as committee diversity increases ($\beta = -0.33$; $p = 0.04$). Taken together, these results suggest that on more diverse committees, white Democrats' citation portfolios shift over time: they become more likely to cite sources introduced earlier by nonwhite lawmakers and less likely to rely on sources outside that set.

4.2.3 | A Temporal Test of Learning: Prior-Term Diversity and Current Evidence Use

One mechanism explaining why white Democrats cite more race-related evidence and more matching sources on racially diverse committees is that they learn from nonwhite colleagues' discussions of race. Yet, as noted above, alternative mechanisms could also generate these patterns, including committee selection, committee jurisdiction, and shared informational environments. To directly test learning as a mechanism, I leverage temporal variation in exposure to nonwhite lawmakers in

committees. If learning is occurring, prior committee diversity should predict current evidence use even when current committee diversity is held constant.

I estimate three OLS regression models with both legislator and term fixed effects. The dependent variable, **Evidence**, is estimated separately for all white lawmakers (Table 6, Column 1), white Democrats (Column 2), and white Republicans (Column 3). The key independent variable, **Prop. Nonwhite on Committee in Prior Term ($t-1$)**, measures, for each legislator–committee–term observation, the proportion of nonwhite members on that legislator's committee in the prior term. I retain this variable only for legislators who served on the same committee in consecutive terms. I also control for the proportion of nonwhite lawmakers on each committee in the current term (t) along with the standard committee-level controls used in prior models.

The results are consistent with my third hypothesis and with the possibility that white Democrats learn from their nonwhite

TABLE 6 | Past committee diversity predicts present evidence use.

	Evidence (white lawmakers)	Evidence (white democrats)	Evidence (white republicans)
	1	2	3
Proportion of Nonwhite on Committee in Prior Term ($t-1$)	1.992** (0.694)	2.535* (0.994)	1.784 [†] (1.008)
Proportion of Nonwhite on Committee in Current Term (t)	1.268 (1.086)	1.719 (1.531)	2.378 (1.915)
% Nonwhite in District	−0.203 (0.904)	0.068 (1.911)	−0.779 (1.166)
Power Committee	0.126 (0.244)	0.077 (0.250)	0.778 (0.812)
Race Committee	−0.085 (0.270)	−0.118 (0.243)	−0.256 (0.748)
No. of Hearings	0.003* (0.001)	0.004* (0.002)	0.0001 (0.002)
No. of Bills Referred	0.0002 (0.0002)	0.0003 (0.0002)	−0.001 [†] (0.0004)
Intercept	−0.360 (1.034)	−2.011** (0.755)	0.862 (1.112)
Legislator Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓
Term Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓
R^2	0.636	0.700	0.600
Adjusted R^2	0.175	0.288	−0.061
Observations	368	200	168

Note: White Democrats exposed to racially diverse committees in the prior term ($t-1$) continue to cite more evidence in the current term (t), net of current-term committee diversity. The dependent variable is the natural log of the total number of evidence-based race statements. Standard errors are robust and clustered by legislator. Alternative specifications, including models with full controls, are reported in Appendix 3.3. Bold values indicate the primary coefficients of interest.

[†] $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

colleagues. In models restricted to white Democrats, the coefficient is positive, statistically significant, and substantively large. A 10-percentage-point increase in nonwhite representation in the prior term is associated with a 28.9% increase in the number of evidence-based race statements made in the current term, holding current-term committee diversity constant.²⁰ These findings are robust to models estimated with non-logged dependent variables (Appendix Table 5.4). They also hold when restricting the sample to committees in which legislators are most likely to grandstand (e.g., Budget, Ways and Means, and Judiciary) (Park 2021), suggesting that the relationship is not limited to settings in which performative comments are uncommon (Appendix Table 4.5). Finally, additional models indicate that committee diversity does *not* predict increased evidence use by nonwhite lawmakers in the current term, which is consistent with my argument that nonwhite lawmakers already possess expertise that is shared with white Democrats on diverse committees (Appendix Table 4.4).

4.2.4 | Race-Based Expertise Affects Substantive Representation

My final hypothesis examines whether race-based expertise is associated with substantive representation. I argue that legislators who frequently cite evidence when discussing race possess expertise on race-related issues, and I expect that one consequence of this expertise is that they will be more effective at advancing and passing the race bills they sponsor. To test this expectation, I scraped the full text of all 87,189 non-commemorative House bills introduced in the 105th–117th Congresses. To identify which bills reference race, I applied the same race-bigram dictionary used to code committee hearing statements. Using a common dictionary for both committee hearing statements and bill text ensures measurement equivalence and allows me to directly test the hypothesized relationship between race-related speech and expertise expressed in committee, the content of race bills, and the likelihood that those bills advance and pass. I validate this measure in Appendix Section 6.

A bill is coded as a race bill if it contains at least one race bigram.²¹ Because my hypothesis concerns whether race is addressed—not how much of a bill is about race—a single reference is sufficient to identify race bills. This inclusive operationalization reflects the fact that expertise can shape targeted provisions or language even when a bill's main subject is not race. Likewise, a bill can afford substantive representation through a single sentence, clause, or amendment. As a robustness check, I re-estimate the models requiring bills to include three or more race references to be coded as race bills (Appendix Table 6.1). The results are consistent across both specifications. Of the 87,189 non-commemorative bills, 6,385 (7%) include at least one race bigram and are coded as race bills. Eighty percent of race bills were introduced by Democrats.

Table 7 reports five OLS models at the member–term level.²² The models include term fixed effects, standard legislative-effectiveness controls, the total number of bills introduced, and legislator-clustered standard errors.²³ I also control for whether the legislator served on a committee with race-related

jurisdiction during that term, which reduces concerns that race-based expertise only facilitates substantive representation for legislators who serve on committees where race is frequently discussed. The dependent variables measure the number of legislators' race bills that (1) received action in committee, (2) were reported out of committee, (3) passed the House, (4) passed both chambers, and (5) became law. The key predictor is the total number of evidence-based race statements a member makes per term.

As expected, the results indicate a positive association between race-based expertise and substantive representation on race bills in three of the five stages: committee action, committee reporting, and House passage. Substantively, each additional evidence-based race statement per term is associated with 0.023 more sponsored race bills passing the House. Put differently, 10 additional evidence-based race statements correspond to about 0.23 House-passed bills, and roughly 44 statements correspond to one additional House-passed bill per term. The substantive effect per evidence statement is modest, as it should be, but it accumulates meaningfully for legislators who consistently ground their race-related arguments in evidence, especially those who do so far more than the chamber average.

There is no statistically significant association between race-based expertise and race bills passing both chambers or becoming law. This is unsurprising, as fewer than 5% of sponsored bills are enacted, and House members' committee-stage expertise has little direct influence over Senate agenda control or voting. Nonetheless, the fact that legislators with race-related expertise move their bills further through the House suggests that such expertise facilitates substantive representation within the chamber, even if the bicameral structure of Congress often prevents ultimate enactment. Importantly, race-based expertise is unrelated to the advancement and passage of non-race legislation, suggesting that the relationship between expertise and effective lawmaking is specific to the issue area in which legislators have expertise (see Appendix Table 4.10). Likewise, the relationship holds when limiting a sponsor's bills to only those referred to committees on which the sponsor serves, suggesting that the association is not simply driven by committee jurisdiction or referral patterns, but persists even when the analysis is limited to bills for which sponsors plausibly possess both committee access and relevant policy expertise (see Appendix Table 4.8).²⁴

5 | Conclusion

Research on descriptive representation has primarily examined whether and how descriptive representatives themselves advance group interests. This paper shows that the consequences of descriptive representation may also extend beyond these lawmakers' own actions. I demonstrate that, when serving on racially diverse committees, white Democrats are more likely to support their race-related statements with evidence and to cite the same sources of evidence as their nonwhite colleagues. I also show that race-based expertise is associated with greater success in advancing and passing race-related legislation. Drawing on data from more than 11,000 committee hearing statements and 87,000 bills, I show that descriptive representation in committees can facilitate substantive representation in policymaking.

TABLE 7 | Legislators who make more evidence-based race statements are more effective at legislating race bills.

	Action in committee (race bills)	Action beyond committee (race bills)	Passed house (race bills)	Passed both chambers (race bills)	Became law (race bills)
	1	2	3	4	5
Total race-based evidence statements	0.039* (0.015)	0.035* (0.014)	0.023* (0.010)	0.004 (0.004)	0.004 (0.004)
Nonwhite	0.061 (0.066)	0.023 (0.057)	−0.030 (0.040)	−0.019 (0.019)	−0.019 (0.019)
Democrat	−0.241 (0.163)	−0.222 (0.133)	−0.247* (0.097)	−0.073 (0.052)	−0.073 (0.052)
On Race Committee	0.068 (0.054)	0.008 (0.046)	0.003 (0.032)	−0.005 (0.015)	−0.005 (0.015)
% nonwhite in district	−0.176 (0.170)	−0.023 (0.136)	0.012 (0.097)	−0.033 (0.045)	−0.033 (0.045)
Intercept	0.257 (0.257)	0.250 (0.255)	0.353 (0.246)	0.222 (0.122)	0.222 (0.122)
Term fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Full controls (Appendix)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
R^2	0.311	0.300	0.211	0.072	0.072
Adjusted R^2	0.297	0.286	0.195	0.053	0.053
Observations	1344	1344	1344	1344	1344

Note: Lawmakers who make more evidence-based race statements are more effective at advancing and passing race bills. Standard errors are robust and clustered by legislator. Full model reported in Table 3.4 in the appendix. Bold values indicate the primary coefficients of interest.

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

These findings also speak to the role of nonwhite lawmakers as sources of race-related expertise within Congress. Additional models indicate that, on average, nonwhite lawmakers are more likely than white lawmakers to substantiate race-related claims with evidence (Appendix Table 4.3). They are not, however, more likely to do so on racially diverse committees (Appendix Table 4.4). This suggests that nonwhite lawmakers may catalyze the race-related evidence that white Democrats later take up in racially diverse committees. Although this paper focuses on information sharing between nonwhite and white lawmakers, some race-related expertise likely circulates among nonwhite lawmakers themselves through caucuses, oversight activity, shared representational agendas, and repeated collaboration on race-related issues. That pathway is important because it may help explain how race-related expertise is developed and reinforced among descriptive representatives. The nonwhite-to-white pathway examined here is valuable for a different reason: it shows that race-related expertise may diffuse beyond descriptive representatives themselves. Because white lawmakers remain numerically central to congressional coalitions, substantive representation often depends not only on whether nonwhite lawmakers raise race-related concerns, but also on whether other lawmakers take up and act on those claims. The finding that white Democrats cite more evidence, and cite some of the same sources as nonwhite colleagues, suggests that committee

diversity can broaden the reach of race-based expertise by shaping how white lawmakers substantiate race-related claims.

These relationships, however, are not uniform across parties. The connection between cross-group contact in committee, race-based expertise, and substantive representation is concentrated among white Democrats. White Republicans are no more likely to cite evidence in diverse committees than in predominantly white ones. This pattern is consistent with the theoretical conditions under which contact is most likely to matter. White Democrats are more likely than white Republicans to share partisan ties, policy goals, and equal-status relationships with nonwhite lawmakers, and Democrats face stronger incentives from their party and constituents to engage in race-related representation (Grose 2011). Therefore, the results suggest that committee diversity matters most when cross-group contact occurs among lawmakers who share relevant policy commitments.

The findings also clarify the institutional conditions under which race-based evidence use emerges. Notably, district racial composition does not predict race-based evidence usage. This is somewhat surprising, given that existing work on the distributive theory of committee organization debates the extent to which legislators' behavior in committee is shaped by electoral incentives (Lazarus 2010; Berry and Fowler 2016). In this case,

however, the null relationship is substantively meaningful. It suggests that white Democrats' evidence use is not simply a response to district-level racial demographics. Instead, the results point to an institutional pathway: committee environments, and the interactions they structure, may shape how legislators acquire and use race-related expertise. This distinction matters for theories of substantive representation because it suggests that representation may be produced not only through electoral incentives from constituents but also through information exchange within legislative institutions.

Taken together, these results point to several avenues for future research. Beyond committee diversity, do legislators' lived and personal experiences or occupational backgrounds foster expertise on race? How do nonwhite lawmakers share evidence and expertise with one another, and how does that process differ from nonwhite-to-white information sharing? Do witnesses in hearings shape lawmakers' engagement with race-related evidence? And do similar mechanisms operate for other underrepresented groups, such as female legislators and LGBTQ+ legislators? Addressing these questions will help clarify whether, how, and for whom committee diversity interacts with expertise to shape substantive representation.

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Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Endnotes

¹ Some scholars find that party identification and the percentage of Black and Latino constituents in a district better predict lawmakers' support for racially salient legislation than race (Swain 1995; Hero and Tolbert 1995; Knoll 2009; Grose 2011).

² I distinguish attention to race from evidence use about race. A committee may discuss race frequently without white lawmakers substantiating their race-related claims or drawing on the same sources as their nonwhite colleagues.

³ One precondition of this argument is that nonwhite lawmakers regularly cite evidence when discussing race, thereby creating the opportunity for white lawmakers to learn from their evidence use. Figure 1 and Appendix Table 4.3 show that nonwhite lawmakers are more likely than white lawmakers to cite evidence when discussing race.

⁴ One concern is that citation convergence could reflect performative engagement rather than learning. For instance, white legislators may defensively or disingenuously repeat sources cited by nonwhite colleagues (i.e., "virtue signaling"). In a hand-coded training set of race-related hearing statements ($n = 5000$), undergraduate research assistants coded each statement as "neutral" (i.e., no affect, just content) or "negative" (i.e., explicitly discussing nonwhite lawmakers in negative terms). Ninety-eight percent of race statements were coded as neutral. This does not suggest that negative language toward nonwhite lawmakers or performative citations never occur in committee hearings, but it does indicate that such behavior is rare, not systematic, and unlikely to drive the results.

⁵ I use hearing statements collected by Park (2021) for the 105th–114th Congresses. I worked alongside Park to clean hearing data for the 115th–117th Congresses.

⁶ One concern is that legislators may mention race not only as a form of representation but also in explicitly negative or racist ways. I address this possibility by coding for negative and neutral race statements in a training set of 5000 randomly sampled race statements. Statements were coded as negative if the legislator spoke about nonwhite individuals in a negative or racist way, and neutral otherwise. Ninety-eight percent of all race statements were coded as neutral, meaning that the overwhelming majority were not explicitly negative. As a result, I do not incorporate tone as an independent variable in this analysis.

⁷ Importantly, my definition of evidence differs from work measuring information in congressional committee hearings (Ban et al. 2024). Legislators *cite* evidence to make and defend arguments while they *acquire* information through witness testimony, experts, staff, and other sources.

⁸ Legislators do cite witness testimony in their committee hearing statements as evidence. If legislators cite a testimony that includes both a claim and a source, I count it as evidence usage.

⁹ I intentionally do not construct this variable at the statement level. Legislators' statements within a hearing are not independent. Rather, lawmakers often engage in dialogue with witnesses throughout their allotted speaking time, meaning multiple statements from the same legislator may be connected (Eldes et al. 2024). Therefore, calculating this variable at the member-committee-term level best reflects the structure of committee hearing discussions. Since many statements by the same lawmaker may be similar, I clustered standard errors by legislator in all models.

¹⁰ In Section 5 of the appendix, I present summary statistics that describe the skewness of each variable. I also re-estimate the models presented in the main text using the non-transformed variables. The results, presented in Appendix Tables 5.2 and 5.3, are consistent with those reported in the main text.

¹¹ This finding holds in a multivariate model with member-level controls and term fixed effects. In Appendix Table 4.3, I regress the number of evidence-based race statements per term on an indicator for whether a lawmaker is nonwhite. The coefficient is positive and statistically significant ($\beta = 0.249$, $p = 0.00$), suggesting that nonwhite lawmakers are significantly more likely than white lawmakers to use evidence when discussing race in committee hearings.

¹² Defining whether a committee's primary jurisdiction is race-related is necessarily difficult. Because my outcome variable measures how frequently race and evidence-based race statements are referenced in committees, I need to define race-jurisdiction committees *ex ante* rather than based on my own measures. To do so, I identify three committees whose formal jurisdictions most directly encompass the policy domains that the race-in-Congress literature most often treats as race-salient. I intentionally make this measure conservative. Every committee deals with race to some extent, but the purpose of this control variable is to identify the committees that are most likely to deal with race-related policies as a result of their jurisdictions. Judiciary is the clearest case because its jurisdiction directly encompasses civil rights, civil liberties, and immigration,

making it the central committee for race-related legal and membership questions. Ways and Means is included because it has jurisdiction over major social service and income-support programs, and the literature treats social welfare as central to minority interests in Congress (Minta and Sinclair-Chapman 2013; Ellis and Wilson 2013). Natural Resources is included because its jurisdiction explicitly encompasses Native American affairs. Although other committees certainly address race-related issues (e.g., Education and Financial Services), these three are the primary committees whose formal jurisdictions most directly encompass race-related policy domains. If the findings hold with the addition of this control, that would suggest that the relationship between committee diversity and evidence-based race statements is not confined to committees whose jurisdictions most directly concern race-related issues.

¹³ This identification strategy strengthens inference but does not establish causality. Although legislator and term fixed effects absorb stable differences across members and common shocks across terms, they do not account for within-term, member-level unobservables.

¹⁴ Two-way fixed effects rely on the assumption of linear additive effects (Imai and Kim 2021), which may be violated when including both unit- and time-specific fixed effects. To assess whether two-way fixed effects influence the results presented here, I reestimate all models without term fixed effects (and with time-based controls) in the appendix. The results are consistent across both specifications.

¹⁵ In appendix models without term fixed effects, I include a variety of control variables, including member-level characteristics that could theoretically vary over time—such as party identification, district racial diversity, ideology, seniority, and vote share—all of which may influence white lawmakers' use of evidence. I also control for majority party status and the overall racial diversity of the House, as both factors may shape whether race-based evidence is referenced. Table 3.1 in the appendix reports this model with all controls included.

¹⁶ The unit of analysis is the legislator–committee–term. Because the dependent variable is evidence use within race-related hearing statements, legislators who never discuss race in committee hearings are not included in the data set. This explains why the number of observations in regression models is smaller than if all legislators were included during my time series.

¹⁷ In Sections 4 and 5 of the appendix, I demonstrate that this result is consistent across three alternative model specifications. First, Appendix Table 4.1 reports a model without legislator fixed effects, instead interacting a binary indicator for white lawmakers with the percentage of nonwhite lawmakers on the committee. Second, Appendix Table 4.2 uses a dependent variable measuring the proportion of evidence-based to total race statements. Third, Appendix Table 5.2 presents results using the original, non-transformed dependent variable. Across all three specifications, the results remain largely consistent with the main findings reported in the main text. In Section 9 of the appendix, I describe my empirical strategy for measuring evidence usage in non-race statements and report findings.

¹⁸ In the lagged race-statements model, the coefficient is statistically significant at the 0.08 level. In the Judiciary-only model, it is statistically significant at the 0.09 level. In both cases, the smaller sample likely explains why the estimates do not reach conventional levels of statistical significance.

¹⁹ In Appendix Table 5.3, I estimate the same model using the non-transformed dependent variable. The results are consistent.

²⁰ Notably, the model estimated for white Republicans has a p-value ≤ 0.1 ; however, I caution against interpreting this as evidence of a positive and statistically significant effect. The adjusted R^2 for this model is negative, suggesting that the model fits the data poorly, either because it is overfit or because the sample size is too small. Because this model uses a lagged variable, the sample size is reduced, which may help explain the poor fit.

²¹ The process of deriving these race bigrams is discussed in the first paragraph of the Data & Methods section. The top 100 most frequently mentioned race bigrams are reported in Appendix Section 6.

²² The results of these models are consistent (except for “Passed House”) when estimated using negative binomial count models (Appendix Table 4.6). They also remain consistent when including legislator fixed effects and dropping term fixed effects, which suggests that unobserved, time-invariant factors—such as legislator attributes, district characteristics, committee assignment, pre-existing race-based expertise, or staff quality—do not confound the relationship between race-based expertise and effective lawmaking on race bills (Appendix Table 4.7).

²³ Standard legislative-effectiveness controls include committee chair status; majority- or minority-party leadership status; subcommittee chair status; ideological distance from the floor median; prior service in a state legislature; gender; LGBTQ status; DW-NOMINATE score; seniority; majority-party status; lagged vote share; and total bill sponsorships.

²⁴ This finding is robust to several additional specifications. The results are similar when I use legislative effectiveness scores as an alternative measure of success on race bills (Volden and Wiseman 2014; Volden et al. 2018) (Appendix Table 6.2). The relationship also remains positive and statistically significant when the sample is restricted to Democrats, but not Republicans (Appendix Table 4.10). To ensure that the race-bill measure does not combine bills that expand the rights of nonwhite Americans with bills that may restrict them, I also re-estimate the models separately under Democratic and Republican majorities. The association is positive and statistically significant only under Democratic majorities, when race-related bills are also more likely to expand rights and protections for nonwhite Americans (Appendix Table 4.10). The results are similar in models that replace term fixed effects with legislator fixed effects (Appendix Table 4.7). Finally, to address concerns about endogeneity and reverse causality, I lag the number of evidence-based race statements and use it as the primary independent variable in the same model. The results are consistent, indicating that race-based expertise continues to strengthen legislators' ability to advance and pass race-related legislation (see Appendix Table 4.11).

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section. **Table 2.1:** 20 Randomly selected evidence statements. **Table 2.2:** 20 Randomly selected non-evidence statements. **Table 3.1:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees. **Table 3.2:** Nonwhite and white legislators cite similar sources on racially diverse committees. **Table 3.3:** Past committee diversity predicts present evidence use. **Table 3.4:** Legislators who make evidence-based race statements in hearings are more effective at legislating race bills. **Table 4.1:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees (interaction model). **Table 4.2:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees (proportion

models). **Table 4.3:** Nonwhite legislators make more evidence-based race statements than white lawmakers. **Table 4.4:** Previous exposure to racially diverse committees does not predict evidence usage for non-white legislators. **Table 4.5:** Previous exposure to racially diverse committees predicts evidence usage for white democrats on "grandstanding committees". **Table 4.6:** Legislators who make more evidence-based race statements are more effective at legislating race bills (negative binomial). **Table 4.7:** Legislators who make more evidence-based race statements are more effective at legislating race bills (legislator FE). **Table 4.8:** Race-based expertise and the committee advancement of in-jurisdiction race bills. **Table 4.9:** White legislators cite fewer non-matching sources on racially diverse committees. **Table 4.10:** When race-based expertise leads to race bill passage. **Table 4.11:** Legislators who make more evidence-based race statements are more effective at legislating race bills (lagged evidence variable). **Table 5.1:** Summary statistics for skewed dependent variables. **Table 5.2:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees (non-transformed DV). **Table 5.3:** Nonwhite and white legislators cite similar sources on racially diverse committees (non-transformed DV). **Table 5.4:** Past committee diversity predicts present evidence use (non-transformed DV). **Table 6.1:** Legislators who make evidence-based race statements in hearings are more effective at legislating race bills (3 bigram measure). **Table 6.2:** Legislators who make evidence-based race statements in hearings are more effective at legislating race issue bills (LES). **Table 7.1:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees—stayers sample (any 3 consecutive terms). **Table 7.2:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees—dropping freshmen legislators. **Table 7.3:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees—stayers sample (first 3 consecutive terms). **Table 8.1:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees (lagged race statements). **Table 8.2:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees (committee: judiciary & oversight). **Table 8.3:** White legislators make more evidence-based race statements on racially diverse committees (lag unique sources). **Table 9.1:** White legislators do not make more evidence-based non-race statements on racially diverse committees.